90-Day Onboarding Plan: QA Manager

Overview

This plan covers the first 90 days for a mid-level QA Manager joining a healthcare product organization. The team currently has 4 developers and 2 manual QA engineers, with fragmented testing practices and no unified QA process. The product is a healthcare platform subject to HIPAA compliance requirements, built on a NextJS / Python (FastAPI) / PostgreSQL stack with GitHub Actions for CI/CD.

The plan is structured in three phases — **Orient**, **Build**, and **Scale** — each roughly one month. The immediate priorities are understanding the people, assessing the quality gaps, and establishing the foundations of a structured QA function — all while ensuring HIPAA compliance obligations are embedded into every quality decision from day one.

> **How to use this plan:** This is a living document. Review and adjust it at each phase boundary. Items marked with `[Lead]` are particularly relevant for cross-team and leadership-facing responsibilities.

Guiding Principles

- **Listen before you lead.** Invest the first two weeks in understanding — team dynamics, existing practices, and leadership expectations — before proposing structural changes.
- **HIPAA is not optional.** Every process, test data strategy, tooling decision, and workflow must account for HIPAA compliance from the start.
- **Build trust with the existing QA team first.** Two manual QA engineers are already on the team — understand their frustrations, capabilities, and aspirations before changing anything they own.
- **Make quality visible.** Establish metrics and reporting early so leadership can see QA's contribution clearly.
- **Governance over gatekeeping.** Quality belongs to the whole team; your role is to design the system, not be the sole quality check.
- **Communicate progress.** Regular, transparent updates to leadership and the team build credibility faster than any deliverable.

Phase 1 — Orient & Discover (Weeks 1–4)

Goal: Build deep context about the organization, team, product, HIPAA obligations, and current QA state. Produce a clear strategy before changing any process.

Day 1–2: First Steps

- [ ] Complete HR, IT, and compliance onboarding: accounts, credentials, VPN, required HIPAA training, BAA acknowledgements, and privacy policy review.
- [ ] Request access upfront: GitHub repository (read-only), GitHub Actions pipelines, defect tracking system, test documentation, and any existing quality reporting dashboards.

- ☐ Introduce yourself individually to both QA engineers — schedule dedicated 1:1s in the first week.
- ☐ Meet your manager and ask: *"What does success look like at 30, 60, and 90 days for this role?"*
- ☐ Identify the key ceremonies (sprint planning, standups, retrospectives, release reviews) and add them all to your calendar.
- ☐ Find out where product requirements, architecture decisions, and compliance documentation live.

Week 1: Orientation & Discovery

Goal: Understand the people, product, compliance landscape, and current QA state.

People & Culture

- ☐ Schedule 1:1s with all direct reports (both QA engineers) — listen for pain points, current workload, morale, career goals, and what they wish was different.
- ☐ Meet individually with key stakeholders: Engineering Manager, Product Manager, lead developer, and any compliance or security officer.
- ☐ Understand team rituals and cadences: sprint length, release frequency, code review norms, retrospective health.
- ☐ `[Lead]` Clarify your decision-making scope: what quality decisions are yours to make vs. collaborative vs. escalated to the Engineering Manager?
- ☐ `[Lead]` Understand leadership's definition of quality success — what keeps them up at night, what metrics they care about.

Product & Domain

- ☐ Review available product documentation: feature specifications, user stories, architecture diagrams.
- ☐ Understand the product's core user journeys, primary user types, and most business-critical workflows.
- ☐ Review the product roadmap — understand what is built, what is in progress, and what is planned in the next quarter.
- ☐ Identify which features involve PHI (Protected Health Information) — these are highest risk and require the most rigorous test coverage.
- ☐ Understand the product's data flows: where PHI is collected, stored, transmitted, and accessed.

Process & Quality Landscape

- ☐ Assess the current state of QA: How do the two QA engineers spend their time? What is tested, when, and how?
- ☐ Review any existing test plans, test cases, or manual test checklists.
- ☐ Understand how defects are logged, triaged, prioritized, and resolved — is there an SLA?
- ☐ Review the GitHub Actions CI/CD pipeline: is any automated testing integrated? What runs on pull requests vs. merges?
- ☐ Identify how releases are currently approved — is there a formal release checklist or sign-off process?

- ☐ Understand how HIPAA compliance testing (if any) is currently handled — audit logging, access controls, data masking.

Tools & Process Landscape

- ☐ Inventory the tools currently in use: defect tracker, test case management (if any), project management, documentation, and reporting.
- ☐ Assess GitHub Actions pipelines for any existing test stages.
- ☐ Understand how test environments are managed — who controls staging? Is there a dedicated QA environment?
- ☐ Determine whether any PHI or real patient data is used in test environments (HIPAA violation risk — flag immediately if so).

Phase 1 Early Deliverable (End of Week 1–2): A written QA current-state assessment — current practices, team observations, HIPAA compliance gaps, tooling inventory, and open questions — shared with your manager.

Week 2: Assessment & Strategy

Goal: Translate observations into a structured strategy. Define the target state for QA within this organization.

Risk & Coverage Analysis

- ☐ Map the highest-risk areas of the product: PHI handling, authentication/authorization, audit logging, data exports, integrations with external health systems.
- ☐ Identify untested or undertested areas based on defect history, team feedback, and your own review.
- ☐ Review recent production incidents or escaped defects — identify root cause patterns.
- ☐ Assess HIPAA-specific test gaps: role-based access control testing, audit trail validation, data encryption verification, and breach notification scenarios.

QA Process Design

- ☐ Draft a target QA process model: where in the SDLC does QA participate? What are the entry and exit criteria for each stage?
- ☐ Define a preliminary defect lifecycle: severity/priority definitions, SLA by severity, escalation path for HIPAA-related defects.
- ☐ Draft a release readiness checklist tailored to the product — including mandatory HIPAA sign-off items.
- ☐ Design a test data strategy: how to create, manage, and de-identify or synthesize test data that avoids using real PHI.

Tooling Evaluation & Selection

- ☐ Evaluate whether a test case management tool is needed (e.g., TestRail, Zephyr, Notion-based tracking).
- ☐ Assess whether the 2 QA engineers have the tools they need to do their work effectively.

- ☐ Identify gaps in the GitHub Actions pipeline that a lightweight automation layer could address (e.g., smoke tests on deploy).
- ☐ [Lead] Research AI-powered QA tooling options — evaluate feasibility, compliance requirements (data residency, BAAs for SaaS tools), and ROI for the team context.

Planning

- ☐ Draft a 90-day QA roadmap with milestones aligned to this plan.
- ☐ Identify quick wins: processes or tooling improvements deliverable within 30 days that build credibility.
- ☐ [Lead] Identify whether the QA team capacity (2 engineers) is sufficient for the product's risk profile and roadmap — flag if hiring is needed.

Phase 1 Deliverable (Day 30): A QA Strategy Document covering: current-state assessment, target QA process model, risk-prioritized coverage map, HIPAA compliance test gaps, tooling recommendations, test data strategy, and a 90-day roadmap. Reviewed with your manager and shared with the Engineering Manager.

What Good Looks Like at 30 Days

- You have met individually with every team member and key stakeholder.
- You have a clear, documented picture of the current QA state and its gaps.
- HIPAA-related test gaps have been identified and flagged — no real PHI is being used in test environments.
- A QA strategy document is drafted and reviewed with your manager.
- The two QA engineers feel heard and understand that changes will be made with them, not to them.
- You have identified 2–3 quick wins to deliver in Phase 2.

Phase 2 — Build & Integrate (Weeks 5–8)

Goal: Establish the core QA processes, governance structures, and baseline metrics. Integrate QA into the team's ways of working.

Week 3: Process Design & Team Integration

Defect Lifecycle & Release Criteria

- ☐ Publish the defect lifecycle process: severity/priority definitions, SLA targets per severity, triage cadence, escalation policy.
- ☐ Establish a HIPAA escalation path: any defect involving potential PHI exposure or audit log failure is P1 by definition.
- ☐ Define and publish formal release criteria — minimum regression pass rate, zero open P1/P2 defects, HIPAA sign-off checklist completed.
- ☐ [Lead] Get Engineering Manager and Product Manager alignment on release criteria before publishing team-wide.

QA Ceremonies & Team Cadence

- ☐ Establish a recurring QA team sync (weekly) with the 2 QA engineers: workload review, blocker identification, process retrospective.
- ☐ Integrate QA into sprint ceremonies: ensure QA participates in sprint planning (to identify testability requirements early) and retrospectives.
- ☐ Establish a "Definition of Done" contribution from QA: what test coverage is required before a story can be marked complete.
- ☐ Begin 1:1 cadence with both QA engineers (bi-weekly minimum).

Test Data Strategy Implementation

- ☐ Implement or document the approved test data strategy — synthetic data generation or de-identified data pipeline — to eliminate PHI risk in test environments.
- ☐ `[Lead]` Work with a developer to review whether the current staging environment contains any real PHI; remediate if so.
- ☐ Document the test data creation process so QA engineers can follow it independently.

HIPAA Compliance Testing Integration

- ☐ Establish a HIPAA test checklist as a mandatory part of every release: audit log validation, role-based access control tests, data masking confirmation, session timeout behavior.
- ☐ Ensure both QA engineers understand which test scenarios are HIPAA-required and cannot be deferred.

Week 3 Deliverable: Defect lifecycle process published, release criteria agreed with Engineering Manager and PM, QA ceremonies established, and HIPAA test checklist in use.

Week 4: Metrics, Reporting & Stakeholder Alignment

Metrics Baseline

- ☐ Define the QA metrics that matter for this context: escaped defect rate, regression pass rate at release, defect SLA adherence, open critical/high defect count, and HIPAA test completion rate per release.
- ☐ Establish baselines for each metric using historical data where available.
- ☐ Set up a lightweight reporting dashboard or shared document — this does not need to be a complex tool; a well-structured GitHub wiki page or Notion doc is sufficient.

Stakeholder Reporting

- ☐ `[Lead]` Establish a recurring QA status report cadence for leadership (bi-weekly or per sprint): key metrics, risks, upcoming release readiness, and any HIPAA-related flags.
- ☐ Create a release readiness summary template — a consistent, one-page view of QA status before each release.
- ☐ `[Lead]` Schedule a working session with the Engineering Manager to review QA metrics together and agree on targets.

Cross-Team Governance

- ☐ [Lead] Define QA's role in the pull request process — should QA review certain PRs? Define the criteria.
- ☐ [Lead] Establish an escalation path for quality-related disagreements (e.g., dev wants to ship, QA has open criticals) — document and agree with the Engineering Manager.
- ☐ Identify and document any external compliance reporting requirements relevant to QA (e.g., audit logs reviewed quarterly, penetration testing schedule).

AI Tooling Business Case

- ☐ [Lead] Compile a short business case for AI-assisted QA tooling for the team: potential time savings, coverage gains, HIPAA compliance requirements for any SaaS tools (BAA required), and recommended next step.
- ☐ Socialize with the Engineering Manager before any tool purchase decision.

Phase 2 Deliverable (Day 60): QA processes operating consistently for at least 2 sprints, baseline metrics established and shared with leadership, release criteria in active use, HIPAA compliance checklist embedded in every release, and AI tooling recommendation documented.

What Good Looks Like at 60 Days

- QA processes (defect lifecycle, release criteria, Definition of Done, QA ceremonies) are in place and followed consistently.
- Baseline quality metrics are visible to leadership — escaped defect rate, regression pass rate, HIPAA checklist completion.
- No real PHI is present in any test environment.
- Both QA engineers are operating with clear expectations, and morale is stable or improving.
- Release readiness reports are being produced before each release.
- You have a relationship of trust with the Engineering Manager and Product Manager.

Phase 3 — Stabilize & Scale (Weeks 9–12)

Goal: Demonstrate measurable quality improvement, address capacity or structural gaps, and establish QA's strategic roadmap.

Week 5–6: Stabilize & Deepen

- ☐ Conduct a process retrospective with the QA team: what is working, what is not, what should be adjusted?
- ☐ Review metrics against baselines set in Phase 2 — identify trends and areas needing improvement.
- ☐ Assess whether the QA team's capacity is sustainable: are the 2 QA engineers overloaded? Are there coverage gaps due to team size?
- ☐ [Lead] If capacity is insufficient, prepare a hiring justification with data: coverage gaps, escaped defect trends, roadmap growth. Present to the Engineering Manager.
- ☐ Deepen the HIPAA compliance testing posture: review whether current checks cover all required controls (access control, audit logging, integrity, transmission security).

- ☐ Identify any automation opportunities the QA engineers could realistically own with support — e.g., smoke test scripts in GitHub Actions for the most critical user journeys.

Week 7–8: Scale & Future Planning

- ☐ [Lead] Draft the QA OKRs for the next quarter: align to product roadmap risks, HIPAA obligations, and team growth.
- ☐ [Lead] Prepare a QA roadmap presentation for leadership: where QA is today, where it will be in 6 months, what investment is needed (tooling, headcount, training).
- ☐ Define a career development plan skeleton for each QA engineer — what skills to grow, what ownership to expand.
- ☐ [Lead] Assess whether any external audit readiness work is needed (HIPAA security risk assessment contributions, penetration test coordination, BAA inventory review).
- ☐ Evaluate whether the AI tooling business case from Phase 2 has received approval — if so, begin a controlled pilot.
- ☐ Document all QA processes, metrics, and governance in a shared, durable location (GitHub wiki or equivalent) so the function is not dependent on you personally.

Phase 3 Deliverable (Day 90): QA function operating independently and consistently; quality metrics showing measurable trend improvement vs. Day 1 baseline; QA OKRs for next quarter agreed with leadership; hiring plan or capacity review completed; QA roadmap presented to leadership; all processes documented.

What Good Looks Like at 90 Days

- The QA function has a clear identity, process, and voice within the team.
- Escaped defect rate and regression pass rate are tracked, trended, and moving in the right direction.
- HIPAA compliance test coverage is documented, consistent, and defensible in an audit.
- Both QA engineers have clear roles, growth paths, and are operating more effectively than when you arrived.
- Leadership has visibility into QA's contribution through regular, consistent reporting.
- A QA roadmap and OKRs for the next quarter are agreed and in flight.
- The QA function would continue to operate effectively if you were unavailable for a week.

Key Deliverables Summary

Deliverable	Target Date	Owner
QA Current-State Assessment	End of Week 2	QA Manager
QA Strategy Document (process model, risk map, HIPAA gaps, roadmap)	Day 30	QA Manager
Defect lifecycle process published	Week 3	QA Manager

Deliverable	Target Date	Owner
Release criteria agreed and in use	Week 3	QA Manager + EM + PM
HIPAA compliance test checklist in use	Week 3	QA Manager
Test data strategy implemented (no PHI in test envs)	Week 4	QA Manager + Dev
QA metrics baseline and dashboard	Week 4	QA Manager
Stakeholder reporting cadence established	Week 4	QA Manager
AI tooling business case	Week 4	QA Manager
Process retrospective completed	Week 5	QA Manager
Hiring justification (if applicable)	Week 6	QA Manager
QA OKRs for next quarter	Week 7	QA Manager
QA roadmap presentation to leadership	Week 8	QA Manager
QA process documentation (durable)	Day 90	QA Manager

Success Metrics

Metric	Baseline Target (Day 30)	Target at Day 60	Target at Day 90
Escaped defect rate	Measured and documented	Trending down vs. baseline	Measurably reduced vs. Day 1
Regression pass rate at release	Measured	≥ 85%	≥ 90%
Defect SLA adherence (P1/P2)	Process defined	≥ 80%	≥ 90%
HIPAA checklist completion per release	Checklist created	100%	100%
Real PHI in test environments	Identified	Eliminated	Zero
QA engineer morale	Assessed via 1:1	Stable	Stable or improving
Open P1 defects at release	Tracked	0	0

Ongoing Practices

- **Bi-weekly QA team sync** — workload review, blocker identification, process health check.
- **Per-sprint release readiness report** — consistent template, shared with EM and PM.
- **Monthly metrics review with EM** — trends, targets, risks.

- **Quarterly HIPAA compliance review** — confirm checklist is current and coverage is adequate.
- **1:1s with each QA engineer** — bi-weekly minimum; track career development, morale, and growth.
- **Definition of Done contribution** — QA criteria reviewed in every sprint planning.
- **Retrospective participation** — QA perspective included in every sprint retrospective.

QA Governance Reference

Governance Item	Definition
Release criteria	Regression suite pass rate ≥ 90%, zero open P1 defects, zero open P2 defects without explicit EM sign-off, HIPAA compliance checklist 100% complete
Defect severity — P1 (Critical)	PHI exposure risk, data loss, authentication/authorization bypass, system unavailable in production
Defect severity — P2 (High)	Core user journey broken, audit logging failure, data integrity issue, significant functional regression
Defect SLA — P1	Acknowledged within 2 hours; fix or mitigation within 24 hours
Defect SLA — P2	Acknowledged within 1 business day; resolved within current sprint
HIPAA escalation path	Any defect with potential PHI exposure → immediate P1 → notify EM + compliance officer within 2 hours
Test data policy	No real PHI permitted in any non-production environment; all test data must be synthetic or de-identified
Definition of Done (QA contribution)	Story-level acceptance criteria tested, edge cases identified, defects logged, regression impact assessed
QA sign-off on release	QA Manager or delegated QA engineer confirms release checklist complete before deploy to production
Reporting cadence	Per-sprint release readiness report; bi-weekly executive summary; monthly metrics trend review
Escalation for ship/no-ship disagreement	QA Manager → Engineering Manager → final decision documented with rationale